Civil Service Verbal Ability: Reading, Grammar, and Cohesion

CIVIL-SERVICE · verbal-ability · BoardPrep lesson v1

Official examination scope

CSC verbal scope includes vocabulary, grammar and correct usage, paragraph organization, and reading comprehension in English and Filipino. This lesson uses original examples in both languages; it does not assume that English grammar can be transferred mechanically to Filipino.

Learning objectives

- Find a passage’s central claim and distinguish it from supporting detail.
- Use context to infer word meaning and evaluate a conclusion.
- Apply clear sentence and paragraph relationships in English and Filipino.

1. Central idea, evidence, and careful inference

Read the question first to know whether it asks for a stated detail, central idea, inference, purpose, or evaluation. A central idea explains what the passage as a whole is doing; a detail supports one part. For inference, combine the text with the smallest necessary assumption and reject options that add facts the author never supplies. A change observed after an action does not by itself prove the action caused it. In Filipino, distinguish the pangunahing diwa from pantulong na detalye and make a hinuha that stays within the tekstong binasa.

2. Vocabulary from context

When a word is unfamiliar, reread the sentence and its neighboring sentences. Look for a definition, contrast, example, cause, or repeated idea that narrows the meaning. Substitute a candidate meaning and check whether the sentence still makes sense without changing the author’s claim. In Filipino, inspect affixes and the word’s role in the sentence, then consult a reliable Filipino dictionary when context remains ambiguous. A plausible dictionary meaning may still be wrong for this sentence if it does not fit the surrounding argument.

3. Grammar as a meaning check

For English subject–verb agreement, locate the grammatical subject rather than the nearest noun; intervening phrases do not change the subject’s number. A pronoun should have a clear antecedent and agree in number and reference. Parallel items should use matching grammatical forms. In Filipino, identify the panaguri and simuno in the actual sentence and use the appropriate pang-ugnay and word form; do not impose English agreement patterns where Filipino grammar works differently. Revision should make the intended relationship clearer, not merely sound more formal.

4. Paragraph order and cohesion

A coherent paragraph gives each sentence a job: introduce the point, explain it, support it, or connect it to the next idea. Track reference words, time markers, contrast, and cause-and-effect signals. A sentence that begins with “however” needs a genuine contrast; a pronoun should point to a clear noun; a concluding sentence should follow from the evidence already given. Test a paragraph order by reading the transitions aloud and checking whether the logic remains clear without adding an unstated premise.

Avoid a causal overclaim

Question: A report says processing time fell after a checklist was introduced, but no comparison group was used. What is the strongest conclusion?
1. State only the observed sequence: the decrease followed introduction of the checklist.

2. Check whether another group or design isolates the checklist’s effect.
3. Avoid claiming causation when other changes remain possible.
Answer: The result is promising, but causation is not established.
Check: This conclusion matches the stated evidence and does not add a cause.

Common misconceptions

- The longest option is always the central idea.
- A temporal “after” relationship proves causation.
- English grammatical categories apply identically in Filipino.

Practice patterns

- Label the task before reading options.
- Quote or paraphrase the exact evidence supporting an inference.
- Check grammar against intended meaning in the language used.

Official scope references

Official scope: CSC Examination Announcement No. 03 s. 2026: 09 August 2026 CSE-PPT Scope — Philippine Civil Service Commission — https://csc.gov.ph/phocadownload/userupload/erpo/announcements/2026/ExamAnn_2026_03_Conduct%20of%2009%20Aug%202026%20CSE-PPT_orig%20signed.pdf

Instructional references

Instructional reference: Purdue OWL: Grammar and Mechanics — Purdue Online Writing Lab — https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/grammar/index.html
Instructional reference: Writing and Reading Reasoning Instructional Reference — OpenStax / public instructional reference — https://openstax.org/subjects
Instructional reference: DepEd K to 12 Filipino Curriculum Guide — Department of Education, Philippines — https://www.deped.gov.ph/wp-content/uploads/2019/01/Filipino-CG.pdf
Instructional reference: Balarila ng Wikang Pambansa — Komisyon sa Wikang Filipino — https://kwf.gov.ph/wp-content/uploads/Balarila-ng-Wikang-Pambansa-1.pdf
Instructional reference: KWF Diksiyonaryo ng Wikang Filipino — Komisyon sa Wikang Filipino — https://kwfdiksiyonaryo.ph/

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